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AFTER MY DISAPPOINTMENT over the Montgomery Ward job, I confessed to Jack about my unsuccessful job-hunting expedition in Chicago and mentioned the suggestion from the woman at NBC that I try for a job in the sticks.

Jack was a practical man who firmly believed those announcements advising people to stay at home because there weren't any jobs to be found anywhere. He'd been on the road himself and knew from experience how harsh the times were. But he also knew how disappointed I was after losing the job in Dixon and when I blurted out my dream of breaking into radio, I think his heart went out to me. He was a proud, ambitious man whose own dreams had been crushed by the Depression and I think he understood the fire that was burning inside me. I guess it was the same fire—a drive to make something of myself—that had always burned inside him. At that moment I thought again of Jack in that tiny little shoe store in Springfield and my heart went out to him.

He asked me what I knew about radio stations outside Chicago, which was the source of all the programming people in Dixon listened to. Radio was so new that many Midwestern towns still didn't have a commercial station, but I said I knew of two or three in the tri-cities area of Davenport, Moline, and Rock Island along the Illinois-Iowa border. And I said there were several others further to the west.

Jack heard me out and said that if I wanted to test the advice of that woman in Chicago, he was willing to let me borrow the family car so I could go on the road and look for a job in radio.